mythical'.[97] As Dobbs explains, there was no imminent confrontation at sea. The *Kimovsk* and the *Yuri Gagarin* had long gone, having received orders to turn round and head home on Tuesday. By the time Kennedy's fist was clenching and unclenching, the *Kimovsk* was some 800 miles from the *Essex's* ASW helicopters.[98] Although there were indications that Soviet ships were stopping and turning, US intelligence felt there was insufficient evidence to provide an appreciation to ExComm. McNamara was, unsurprisingly, angry that he and his colleagues were not better informed of events at sea. Notwithstanding the fruits of Dobbs' research, what this also demonstrates is that such an impeccable historical source as the Presidential Recordings cannot always be completely relied upon.

Khrushchev and the Presidium blinked when the ships carrying 'offensive military equipment' turned around. The prospect of having the US navy seize Soviet nuclear warheads or IRBMs was unthinkable for Moscow. Indeed, their captains were instructed to scuttle their ships, rather than allow their cargoes to be captured.[99] The blockade had achieved its initial goal, even though other Soviet and Soviet-chartered ships remained Cuba-bound. Furthermore, there were no indications that Khrushchev was preparing any form of retaliation against West Berlin. But Khrushchev and the Presidium also winked. The preparations at the MRBM and SAM sites accelerated. The four submarines of the Sixty-ninth Brigade sailed onward.

When Kennedy delivered his televised address on 22 October, he spoke of a confrontation lasting months. Within a matter of days, however, the crisis was all over bar the shouting (most of it directed at Moscow from Havana). How that happened, and why the denouement of the crisis passed without significant military confrontation, forms the focus of the next chapter.